

Library chatbots after deployment: a qualitative study with librarians in Spain

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Abstract

This paper examines how librarians experience chatbots after deployment in Spanish university libraries. We conducted 18 semi-structured interviews with librarians from six universities in 2022. Librarians reported reduced repetitive queries but raised concerns about accuracy and user trust.

1. Introduction

Most studies on library chatbots measure student intentions before deployment. Our aim is to understand the post-deployment experience from the librarians' perspective. Research question: how do librarians perceive the impact of chatbots on reference work?

2. Methods

Qualitative design with thematic analysis (Braun and Clarke). Purposive sample of 18 librarians (12 women, 6 men) from six Spanish universities that had used a chatbot for at least one year. Interviews lasted 45 to 70 minutes and were coded in NVivo.

3. Findings

Three themes emerged. First, chatbots handled about 40% of routine questions, freeing time for complex reference work. Second, librarians distrusted chatbot answers to research questions, citing incorrect references generated by the system. Third, students rarely used the chatbot for literature searches, preferring human help.

4. Conclusion

Chatbots are useful for routine services but not yet reliable for research support. Limitations: small sample, only Spanish institutions, and no student data. Future research should combine librarian and student perspectives and test chatbots with verified sources.

References

Braun, V., & Clarke, V. (2006). Thematic analysis. QRP.

Silva, A. (2021). Assistentes conversacionais.